

AFRICA, CENTRAL



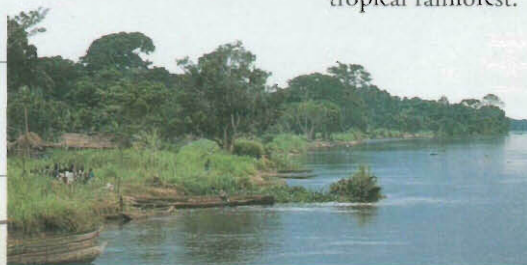
THE EQUATOR RUNS THROUGH Central Africa, affecting not only climate but also ways of life. There are ten countries. All were European colonies with a history of a cruel slave trade.

Although these countries were all independent by the end of the 1960s, they have experienced mixed fortunes. Cameroon is stable, while Democratic Republic Congo (Zaire) and the Central African Republic, have suffered dictatorships. Most Central Africans live by farming.



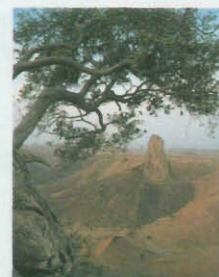
Tibesti

The dramatic cliffs of the volcanic Tibesti Mountains dominate the border between Chad and Libya, in the Sahara Desert. At 3,415 m (11,204 ft) above sea-level, Emi Koussi is the highest peak.



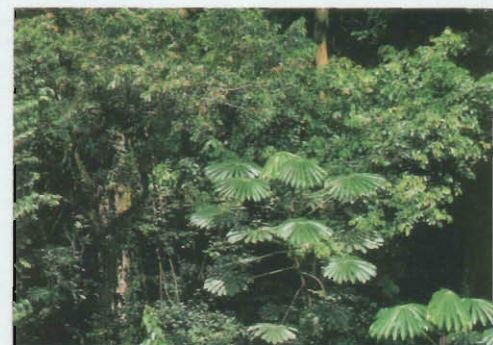
River Congo

One of the longest rivers in the world, the Congo, formerly the Zaire, flows in a great curve for 4,666 km (2,900 miles), crossing the Equator twice. It drains an area of about 3,630,000 sq km (1,400,000 sq miles).



Dry woodland

Tropical rainforests give way to woodland, where the climate is much drier. Acacia and baobab trees grow in this region. The baobabs have very thick trunks that can hold water to feed themselves. Some baobabs on Cameroon's central plateau live for 1,000 years.

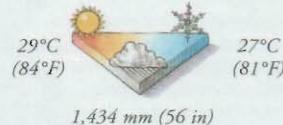


Equatorial rainforest

The hot, humid basin of the River Congo is Africa's largest remaining region of tropical rainforest. Competing for light, a wide variety of trees grow tall, forming a protective canopy that teems with plant and animal life.

Regional climate

The north of the region, the Sahara and Sahel area, is a broad band of dry, dusty land that is starved of rain. By contrast, in the steamy equatorial forests more than 38 mm (1.5 in) of rain falls every day in places. The south experiences the monsoon season between May and October.



Ethnic diversity

There are hundreds of different peoples in Central Africa, each with their own customs and languages. Large groups include the Kongo and Luba, and there are several pygmy groups including the Twa, BaKa, and Mbuti, who live in clearings deep in the rainforests. A growing number of people are moving to towns to escape war, drought, or famine, and because larger centres offer more jobs and food.



Village chief,
Brazzaville, Congo

